

Toiba (LIFT) camp in Pakistan and was in touch with Harakat-ul-Jihad-al-Islami (HUJI) mastermind Shahid Bilal.

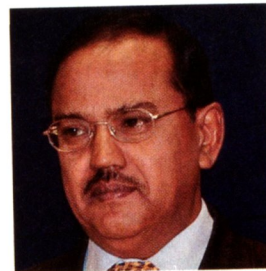
His revelations led Madhya Pradesh Police to a rented three-storeyed building that was being used by Nagori and his accomplices as the SIMI's tactical headquarters. Nagori, the son of a retired police officer from Madhya Pradesh who held a diploma in mechanical engineering and masters degree in journalism and mass communication, also admitted to knowing Mufti Abu Bashir, the mastermind of the Ahmedabad attacks.

The interrogation of the 'Nagori 13' brought to light the existence of the first home-grown Indian terrorist organisation outside of Jammu and Kashmir. A group of over 50 well-educated youth from different parts of the country effortlessly moved among the states. The SIMI, founded in 1977 as an organisation of Islamic students, naturally considered the Taliban—the warrior-students who had captured Afghanistan—their role model. Nagori's anointed Mullah Omar as their leader.

The interrogations led to a wealth of data, phone numbers, safe houses, donors and associates spread across the country. It led to the arrests of 40 SIMI members and the

interrogation reports were shared with police and intelligence agencies across the country. But, curiously, there were no breakthroughs or linkages to other bombings. It was only after the July 26 Ahmedabad blasts—which shocked the nation in its sheer scale, brutality and execution—that the Gujarat Police began to move. Early arrests showed the involvement of the SIMI. With SIMI now emerging as prime suspect in nearly every major strike in the past two years, not acting on interrogation seems like a mind-boggling failure of pre-emptive and preventive intelligence.

Madhya Pradesh Police believes there was no way of stopping the attacks since the SIMI cells operated independently. Besides, they contended that hardcore leaders like Nagori were trained to withstand interrogation and mislead investigators. Security analysts say this is one more reason for a Federal Task Force. Says V. Balachandran, former special secretary, RAW, "Unless you have a legal system where responsibility is assigned and accountability is fixed, such incidents will keep occurring." Since September 2002, the Department of Homeland Security Agency has successfully defended the US against terror attacks. Former IB chief Ajit Doval says, "A federal counter-



"A federal counter-terrorism agency will INTEGRATE intelligence gathering and investigation."

AJIT DOVAL,
FORMER IB CHIEF

THE TRAINING CAMPS

Safdar Nagori organised several camps where men of his faction prepared themselves mentally and physically for jihad and individual target killings of the enemies of Islam

WAGAMON CAMP DECEMBER 9-12, 2007

Nagori calls it the most important camp organised in 2007. Arranged by Hafiz Hussain at Wagamon resort in Kerala's Kottayam district, the camp was attended by 25 activists. According to Nagori, "This camp as well as the Choral camp was the first stage among the four stages of training. Only after the completion of these stages, a participant would be fit for fighting missions." The activists were divided into three teams. One team for trekking was led by Ansar Nadvi. The second team for swimming/river crossing was led by Shibily and the third team for biking and tent pitching was led by Shaduli. Petrol bomb demonstration was given by Aamir Parvez and shooting demo was given by Kamruddin.

HALOL CAMP JANUARY 13-14 2008

This camp was organised at Halol, near Vadodara. It was a local camp organised by the Mumbai-based Abdus Subhan alias Tauqir who as the Gujarat Police suspect was the bomb maker in the Ahmedabad blasts. Participants at the camp included Sajid Mansuri of Vadodara and Arif Kagzi of Ahmedabad. Though Nagori was in Vadodara, he did not attend the camp due to security reasons. Training was given in swimming, rock climbing, biking.

DHARWAD CAMP AUGUST 2007

Attended by 17 people, the camp targeted the medical students of KIMS, Hubli. The central leadership was represented by Shibily and Hafiz. KIMS has a SIMI unit with

three Ikhwan (SIMI activists), Asif, Allah Baksh and Mirza Beg. They were able to recruit seven cadres.

CHORAL TRAINING CAMP SEPTEMBER 27, 2007

Organised at a farmhouse near Indore marking the group's six-month completion. Sixteen participants were taught how to make petrol bombs and shoot with air rifles.

SECOND CHORAL TRAINING CAMP NOVEMBER 15, 2007

Sixteen participants were taught the same drill in this camp.

HALIYAL CAMP DECEMBER 2007

Held at the farmhouse of a SIMI activist in Karnataka. Eighteen people were told to learn martial arts.